

Grammar

Articles

- In English, there are three articles— **a**, **an** and **the**.
- **A** and **an** are called **indefinite articles** because they do not refer to a particular noun.

Examples: • She boiled **an** egg in **a** pan.

- I saw **a** lady at the factory gate.

/NOTE

- The nouns **egg**, **pan** and **lady** in the above examples do not point at a definite thing or person.

- **The** is known as the **definite article**. It refers to a particular noun.

Examples: • **The** stars are twinkling.

- **The** principal of our school met **the** class teachers.

- In the above sentences, article **the** points at particular things (stars) and persons (principal class teachers).

Indefinite Articles (a, an)

Use of article 'a'

- We use **a** before a singular countable noun that begins with a consonant sound.

Examples: • **a** cot, **a** rug.

- We also use **a** before a word that begins with a vowel when written, but begins with a consonant sound when pronounced.

Example: • Unicorn— it begins with the vowel 'u' when written, but begins with a 'yu' sound when pronounced. So, we write '**a** unicorn'.

- We use **a** before a word that begins with a vowel when written, but begins with a 'w' sound when pronounced.

Example: • One-sided story—it begins with the vowel 'o' when written, but begins with a 'w' sound when pronounced.

So, we write: **A** one-sided story was told to us.

Use of article 'an'

- We use article **an** before a singular countable noun that begins with a vowel sound.
Example: • **an** ostrich
- We also use **an** before a word that begins with a consonant when we write it down, but begins with a vowel sound when we pronounce it.
Example: • **an** MLA
- We use **an** before a word that begins with a silent 'h'.
Example: • **an** honest citizen

Let us take a look at the table with more examples.

Use of article 'a'	a house, a one-way road, a university, a European lady
Use of article 'an'	an eagle, an MP, an heir, an hour, an NCC cadet

More about Use of Indefinite Articles

We use indefinite articles **a** and **an** in various sentences in different contexts.

We use **a/an**:

1. to refer to a single countable noun when it is used for the first time.
Example: • A lady got down from **a** taxi.
2. in the sense of **one**.
Examples: • She had **a** toast and **an** apple for breakfast.
• She buys **a** book every month.
3. to refer to a single countable noun in **general**.
Examples: • A judge ensures that justice is done.
• **An** acrobat performs difficult acts.
4. to refer to **each**.
Examples: • She saves ₹10,000 **a** month.
• The electrician charges ₹1,000 **an** hour.
5. in phrases to express speed, quantity, price, etc.
Examples: • Tomatoes cost ₹50 **a** kilo.
• Renu drove at 80 kilometres **an** hour on her way to office yesterday.
6. with some phrases indicating numbers.
Examples: • She bought **a** couple of shirts.
• I kept **a** few medicines in my purse.
• We saw **a** hundred flowers blooming in the park.
7. to imply the whole class in a general sense.
Examples: • **A** cheetah can run very fast.
• **An** owl can see in the dark.
8. before a proper noun to make it a common noun.
Examples: • She is **a** Serena Williams in the making.
• He thinks he is **a** Neeraj Chopra.

9. before a single countable noun to express joy, surprise, horror, disgust, etc.

- Examples:
- What **a** funny clown he is!
 - What **an** awesome gift!
 - How horrifying **a** dream it was!

10. before the name of a person used with a title and we imply that she/he is a stranger.

- Examples:
- **A** Mr Sinha has come to meet you.
 - **A** Dr Sharma has replaced her.

11. to refer to the names of occupations.

- Examples:
- My father is **an** architect.
 - Sheena is **a** trapeze artist.

12. in some phrases.

- Examples:
- Give me **a** break, it is **an** order, earn **a** living, in **a** harsh voice, in **an** hour, in **a** minute.

Use of the Definite Article— The

The is used:

1. when we refer to a noun that we have already mentioned.

- Example:
- I bought a car. **The** car has six air bags for safety.

2. before a singular noun used to represent the whole class.

- Examples:
- **The** octopus has eight tentacles.
 - **The** cobra is very venomous.

3. before an adjective used as a noun.

- Examples:
- **The** injured were given first aid.
 - Smartphones are popular among **the** young as well as **the** old.

4. to refer to a thing which is only one of its kind.

- Examples:
- **The** sun, **the** equator, **the** sky, **the** sea.

5. with singular and plural nouns when we refer to someone or something in particular.

- Examples:
- Get **the** coffee from **the** flask.
 - **The** girls are ready to go out for dinner.
 - I know **the** boys of your class.

6. before a superlative adjective.

- Examples:
- My brother is **the** best athlete in our school.
 - Shirish is **the** tallest member in this group.

7. with a noun that is specified by a relative clause or a prepositional phrase.

- Examples:
- **The** boy who greeted me is my cousin.
 - **The** watch that Rahul bought is very nice.

8. with proper nouns when one refers to families.

- Examples:
- I have never met **the** Guptas.
 - **The** Goyals live in this colony.

9. before an adjective in the comparative degree to indicate a selection out of two.

- Examples:**
- She is **the** better singer of the two finalists.
 - He is **the** more sincere of the two workers.

10. before a proper adjective when it refers to a nation or people of a nationality.

- Examples:**
- **The** French appreciate art a lot.
 - **The** Indians love their country.

11. before common nouns that are names of musical instruments.

- Example:**
- She is learning to play **the** sitar.

12. before ordinal numbers.

- Example:**
- **The** first student in that queue is our class monitor.

13. before some expressions of time.

- Examples:**
- **The** morning, **the** previous week, **the** following month, **the** next day.

14. before some comparatives in certain constructions.

- Example:**
- **The** harder you work, **the** better you will do.

Remember:

Sometimes, we do not use **the** with 'next' and 'last' when we use these words to indicate the period immediately before or after the present time.

- Examples:**
- I met my uncle **last** week.
 - We will go to Mumbai **next** week.

Use of the Definite Article 'The' with Proper Nouns

We should not use articles before proper nouns. But we use **the** with the names of:

Hotels, cinemas, theatres	Rivers, seas, oceans, deserts, gulfs, straits, canals	Mountain ranges	Holy books and some famous books	Newspapers and magazines	Ships and trains	Well-known buildings and some works of art	Countries which have plural names and groups of islands	Countries that include an adjective followed by a noun
The Globe Cinema/ The Royal Hotel	The Yamuna/ The Indian Ocean/ The Sahara Desert/ The Red Sea	The Alps/ The Western Ghats	The Guru Granth Sahib/ The Sun Also Rises	The Indian Express/ The Week	The Rajdhani Express/ The Golden Chariot/ The HMS Victory	The Rashtrapati Bhavan/ The Starry Night	The Maldives/ The Philippines	The United Kingdom/ The United Arab Emirates

Omission of Articles

We do not use articles before:

1. proper nouns.

Example: • Neeta lives in Jaipur, the capital of Rajasthan.

2. common nouns used in the widest sense.

Example: • Children love to play.

3. abstract nouns and abstract ideas.

Examples: • Laughter is infectious.

• Life is beautiful.

4. material nouns.

Examples: • She gifted me a bracelet made of silver.

• Gold is expensive.

• Paper is used to make carry bags.

NOTE

- We do not use **the** before common, abstract and material nouns, but when the noun is made particular and qualified by a word, phrase or clause, we use **the**.

Examples: • The kindness of my aunt is known to all.

• The courage of the soldiers was appreciated by everyone.

- When an abstract noun is made specific and is restricted to a person or thing, we use **the**.

Example: • The wisdom of Socrates was known to the people of Athens well.

5. names of meals and games.

Examples: • Mother prepared lunch for the guests.

• Cricket is my favourite game.

6. nouns like hospital, office, college, school, bed, temple, church, etc., when we refer to the main purpose they are used for.

Examples: • I always reach school on time.

• Mother has gone to office.

NOTE

- If we refer to nouns like office, hospital, bed, temple, etc., for other than their primary purpose, we use **the**.

Examples: • She went to the hospital to meet her friend.

• He has gone to the school to repair the furniture.

- When we refer to a specific meal or eatable which is modified by an adjective phrase or clause, we use an article.

Examples: • The lunch she served was delicious.

• I found the vegetable curry very spicy.

7. names of languages used as nouns.

Example: • He cannot speak German at all, though he lived in Germany for years.

/NOTE

- When we use the name of a language as an adjective, we use **the** before it.

Example: • She found **the** Swedish language simple.

8. plural nouns that are used to represent a whole class.

Examples: • **Scooters** are used by many delivery boys.
• **Lions** are ferocious.

9. names of means of transportation used in general sense.

Examples: • Let us go to Nainital by **car**.
• I love to travel by **train**.

More about Omission of Articles

We do not use articles when:

1. a possessive adjective is placed before a noun.

Examples: • This is **my** hat.
• She forgot **her** badge in the class.

2. someone is addressed.

Examples: • You can wait here, **lady**.
• Sit here, **child**.

3. countables are used in pairs.

Examples: • She was in a mess from **head to toe**.
• Both **mother** and **child** are fine.

4. we use a noun denoting title, rank, station.

Examples: • **Sir** Mick Jagger, **Maharaja** Hari Singh, **King** George V.

5. we use expressions like 'kind of', 'sort of', 'type of'.

Examples: • What **kind of** party is this?
• What **sort of** dress is this?
• What **type of** resort is this?

6. we use certain verbal phrases.

Examples: • To set sail, to lose sense, to join hands, to pursue goals.

7. we use some prepositional phrases.

Examples: • **By** train, **by** heart, **at** dawn, **at** risk, **at** times, **at** lunch, **in** fact, **in** action, **in** detail, **for** ages, **for** instance, **for** nothing, **on** deputation, **on** leave.

8. we use any, some, neither, either, another, each, etc., before a noun.

Examples: • I kept three pens in **every** packet.
• **Each** day brings new hope.
• Let us go to **another** restaurant now.

9. a noun refers to some time and we use 'last' before it.

Example: • This house was constructed **last** year.

10. we refer to a place or institution named after some person or place.

Example: • Annamalai University, Deen Dayal Upadhyay Marg.

11. we use some exclamatory phrases.

Examples: • He is lost and sad. Poor child!

• Great sportsman! He played exceptionally well.

Repetition of Articles

1. When we have two or more adjectives for the same noun, we use an article only before the first adjective.

Example: • She has **a** pink and purple gown. (one gown that is partly pink and partly purple)

2. When we refer to two nouns, we use an article before each of them.

Example: • She has **a** pink and **a** purple gown. (two gowns, one is pink and the other is purple)

3. When we use two or more connected nouns to refer to the same person or thing, we place an article before the first noun only.

Example: • **The** actor and director was awarded yesterday. (one person is implied)

4. When we use two or more connected nouns to refer to different persons or things, we use an article before each of them.

Example: • **The** actor and **the** director were awarded yesterday.

Usage of Few and Little

A. Sometimes, we use **few**, **a few** and **the few**, when we refer to countable nouns.

1. **Few** is used to imply 'hardly any'.

Example: • Few people can understand it.

2. **A few** means a small number.

Example: • Due to heavy rains, **a few** students attended school yesterday.

3. **The few** means a small number, but all there are.

Example: • **The few** neighbours, who knew the old man, came to meet him when he moved out.

B. Sometimes, we use **little**, **a little** and **the little** when we refer to uncountable nouns.

1. **Little** implies 'hardly any' and it has a negative connotation.

Example: • **Little** did we guess that the outcome of our action would be so significant.

2. **A little** means a small amount (of something).

Example: • **A little** butter was left in the bowl.

3. **The little** means a small amount, but all there is.

Example: • **The little** butter, which remained after making a pie, was added to the soup.



EXERCISE

I. Use 'a', 'an' or 'the' to complete the given sentences. Put a cross (×) where no article is required.

1. Sneha was attending meeting which had been going on for hour, when she was called to auditorium of her college.

2. I poured litre of milk from blue bottle.
3. President of our country delivered speech on TV yesterday.
4. one-way street leads to my house at end of main market.
5. Vibha reached New Delhi Railway Station by taxi and paid fare in cash.
6. Amazing dancer! She danced with grace of professional dancer.
7. I joined Japanese classes last year and I feel it is language that can be learned well with practice.
8. European policeman stopped car to check driver's licence.
9. Heena painted unicorn on canvas and put it up for sale in exhibition.
10. children are happy after playing football for some time.
11. South-East Asians usually love spicy food.
12. Suresh was tallest in our class when I was in school.
13. Varsha decided to donate some money every year. She gives lac year to help needy.
14. traffic policeman ensures that drivers follow traffic rules.
15. crocodile is large amphibious reptile and is carnivore.

II. Fill in the blanks with 'a', 'an' or 'the'. Put a cross (×) where no article is required.

1. My grandfather is honourable man who has been very active all his life. He was NCC cadet, trained scuba diver and mountaineer when he was young.
2. Wular Lake is one of largest fresh water lakes in Asia.
3. Chetna is Mirabai Chanu of our town.
4. She has gone to hospital for health check-up.
5. delivery boy is at door with big packet of patties and orange cake.
6. Many farmers grow rice in India but few grow spices.
7. new flyover was inaugurated by MLA.
8. I added little sugar to my cup of tea as it was not sweet enough.
9. I really liked pen set that you gave me.
10. last musician in that corner can play flute very well.

III. Choose the correct option to complete the sentence. If no article is required, choose (d).

1. What time do you have lunch?
 (a) an (b) the
 (c) a (d) No article is required
2. The darkest cloud has silver lining.
 (a) an (b) the
 (c) a (d) No article is required

3. She goes to church on Sundays.
 (a) an (b) the
 (c) a (d) No article is required
4. Your brother is honest officer.
 (a) an (b) the
 (c) a (d) No article is required
5. The more she gets, more she wants.
 (a) an (b) the
 (c) a (d) No article is required

Subject – Verb Agreement

- A singular subject takes a singular verb.

Example: • Meenu composes poems. (Subject 'Meenu' is singular; Verb 'composes' is singular).

A singular verb ends with 's' or 'es', e.g. throws, decides, washes, passes.

- A plural subject takes a plural verb.

Example: • Lions eat other animals. (Subject 'Lions' is plural; Verb 'eat' is plural).

A plural verb does not end with 's' or 'es', e.g. skate, bring, draw.

NOTE

- A verb must always agree with its subject in number.
- In a sentence, the verb changes according to the number and person of the subject.
- When a pronoun is used as the subject, subject-verb agreement is applied accordingly.

Examples: • He is in school right now. (Subject 'He' is a singular pronoun in the third person. Verb 'is' is a singular verb).

- They are tired. (Subject 'They' is a plural pronoun in the third person. Verb 'are' is a plural verb).

- I am a student. (Subject 'I' is a singular pronoun in the first person. Verb 'am' is used with it).

- You are a good speaker. (Subject 'You' is a singular pronoun in the second person. Verb 'are' is used with it).

- 'You' is used both in the singular and plural. It takes a plural verb.

Some Important Rules to Remember

(A)

Rule	Rule	Rule	Rule
When two or more singular subjects are joined by 'and'	When two singular nouns refer to the same person	When two singular nouns refer to two persons	When two subjects express a single idea